

Mission: Transmission

MPEG-4 is a standard to compress still images, audio and video coded files so that it can be streamed on cellphones, broadband as well as digital television

Future of DTH

DTH market is projected to grow by over 30 per cent by 2012 according to reports

DTH Comparison

It received a good rating on picture quality, but scored lowest on pricing and package structure. The highest average rating for picture quality went to BIG TV, followed closely by Airtel. Similarly, both BIG and Airtel received the highest user rating for package pricing. Since Videocon is the newest entrant in this space, it received very few votes to be considered in the comparison of specific parameters.

The survey also revealed some secondary findings as well. About 60 per cent of the respondents who took the survey were on DTH, while 20 percent were on regular cable. Cable set-top boxes were preferred by 17 per cent of the respondents. About 73 per cent of the respondents still own regular CRT TVs, while 15 per cent have HD ready and 11 per cent have full HD LCDs.

promising and are directed at kids. TataSky seems to be the most trusted of the lot. Rahul Choudhary from Haldwani Uttarkhand says, "It has good service and the Tata quality." But since it's the most popular

TATASKY+

Currently it is the only DTH service that offers DVR (Digital Video Recording), which means that you get to record 90 hours of TV content in its internal hard drive and watch it at your convenience. This is truly the wet dream of any hardcore TV buff. In addition to recording, users get to record one programme while watching another, pause a live telecast and even rewind a TV programme that you are watching. This way those unexpected interruptions don't mean missing out on that crucial part of your favourite soap. All this doesn't come cheap. The hardware itself will set you back by Rs. 8999.

it got a lot of criticism as well. A few complained the interface is slow. Rahul Mathur from Bhopal says, "Tata Sky, even after many software updates, seems to be very slow and hangs couple of times". How-

going places. The DTH provider has armed itself with a lot of innovative interactive services and some exclusive features such as a Universal remote. Saravana Pradeesh from Tirupur says he "chose Airtel for the universal remote and customer service". On the

interactive front, Airtel has some interesting innovations. With their iNet feature, customers can get updates on the latest news, stocks from your portfolio, Bollywood gossip and the latest weather with widgets. "We have partnered with NDTV for our News widget and CNBC for Stocks", said Mr. Sugato Banerji, Chief Marketing Officer - DTH, Bharti Airtel. As for plans, the structure is decent. If say you're a music buff, you could go in for a base pack of 110 channels for Rs. 127 and go in for a music top up for Rs. 25, which has a few channels and World Space radio thrown in.

Dish TV

Dish is the oldest DTH provider around. You can access content from Shaadi.com and search for potential partners through the ShaadiActive service. The content is not live but is updated every week. Similarly you can access content from monster.com and ICICI Bank.

As for packages, they've got three packages that cover an assortment of everything, while *à la carte* channels can be ordered as per preference. Respondent Anil Kumar, says "The packages are good", however he adds, "I've had but poor reception during rainy days".

BIG TV

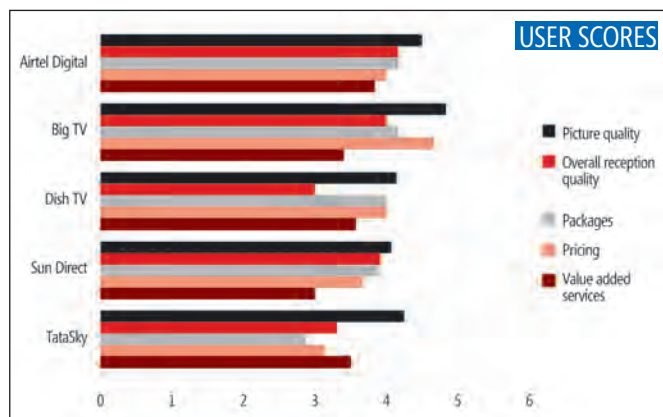
BIG has been quite big on our user-based score charts. It scores high in picture quality, thanks to MPEG4. It also has good start-up plans, with three months subscription clubbed with the hardware cost. BIG is focussing heavily on pay-per-view movies, but we couldn't find any interesting titles playing. "Big TV has its issues but it does provide me with many options. There are more channels, in more languages (and in the original languages), and the picture quality is definitely better. And it is reasonably priced", says Kirtana Krishnan from Thane.

Sun Direct

Sun has a strong presence in the South. It also has packs for other regions and languages. This way, you can opt for the Marathi pack (depending on your language) if you're from Maharashtra.

Videocon d2h

Videocon combined its electronics and consumer goods background to bundle LCD TVs and DVD players with in built DTH receivers. They've even come up with DVD players that have in built DTH. It also has some interesting features on the interface. For example, a 12 picture in picture mosaic to browse channels rather than using the EPG. It also has tickers for stock, cricket and news updates that form an overlay over the programming being viewed. Their packages are decent but as per the web site information even their Diamond pack which is their highest end offering needs an English movie add on priced at Rs. 25 to make it complete. Like Sun Direct, Videocon d2h also has packs for every region. **d**



TataSky

TataSky has been around for quite some time. Among other things, TataSky provides customers with 24x7 support in 11 languages. Their channel packages seem to be a tad on the more expensive side. However, they have the maximum number of interactive services - many of which very

ever on the positive side, we got comments like this one too. "Their customer service is good" Narendra from Meerut says "its customer support is also very responsive and supportive".

Airtel Digital

With its Saif and Kareena campaigns, Airtel seems to be